

Module # 1

CPC Vision, Values and Commitments

What makes CPC distinctively what it is? (your observations)

I. CPC's Three Core Values:

Concerns our *ambition, confidence, and strategy*

1. Our ultimate ambition IS to *glorify God, really, as through Christ!*

It is the ultimate imperative that directs all of RH

Psa. 86:9

All the nations you have made shall come
and bow down before you, O Lord,
and shall *glorify* your name.

It was the ultimate passion of Christ even as "the Christ".

John 12:28

Father, *glorify* your name." Then a voice came from heaven, "I have glorified
it, and I will *glorify* it again."

IT is the ultimate purpose of the Kingdom of God and the church

Titus 2:13

while we await the blessed hope and the manifestation of the *glory* of our
great God and Savior, Jesus Christ.

Rev. 1:6

and made us to be a kingdom, priests serving his God and Father, to him be
glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen.

Rev. 4:11

"You are worthy, our Lord and God, to receive *glory* and honor and power, for
you created all things, and by your will they existed and were created."

It is the ultimate prayer of all true believers...

Jude 1:24

Now to him who is able to keep you from falling, and to make you stand
without blemish in the presence of his *glory* with rejoicing, 25 to the only God
our Savior, through Jesus Christ our Lord, be *glory*, majesty, power, and
authority, before all time and now and forever. Amen.

Westminster Confession of Faith.

After describing God as one who is *infinite in being and perfection... immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty, most wise, most holy, most free, most absolute... most righteous, most loving, gracious, merciful... all-sufficient not standing in need of any creature which he hath made, not deriving any glory from them but only manifesting his won glory in, by, unto and upon them... as nothing is to him contingent or uncertain, etc. etc* -- the confession is compelled to add, *to Him is due from angels and men, and every other creature, whatsoever worship, service or obedience he is pleased to require of them..*¹

How Then is God glorified?

1. God is glorified when we acknowledge that God has glorified himself in the gospel of Jesus Christ such as to effect the whole culture of our church.

John 13:31

When he had gone out, Jesus said, "Now the Son of Man has been glorified, and God has been glorified in him. 32 If God has been glorified in him, God will also glorify him in himself and will glorify him at once.

John 17:1

After Jesus had spoken these words, he looked up to heaven and said, "Father, the hour has come; glorify your Son so that the Son may glorify you,

1Pet. 4:11

so that God may be glorified in all things through Jesus Christ. To him belong the glory and the power forever and ever. Amen.

- ✓ Therefore, the means wherein God is glorified is Christ acting for us, and in us, for God's glory!

John 17:4

I glorified you on earth by finishing the work that you gave me to do.

John 15:8

My Father is glorified by this, that you bear much fruit and become my disciples.

- ✓ Even God answers our prayers for the purpose of glorifying himself in His Son! E.g. we pray according to Christ and in his name!

John 14:13

I will do whatever you ask in my name, so that the Father may be glorified in the Son.

2. Our Vision:

What Does the "to glorify God" change? What kind of a church would we have to be so that our practice reflects God's redemptive history as directing all people to Christ as the one true reflection of God's glory and the exact imprint of God's very being, and who alone sustains all things by his powerful word, who is the only mediator between God and humanity so that He might come to have first place in everything? (Heb.1:3, 2Tim.2:5, Col.1:18)

- ✓ From *Human Centered* to a *Christ Centered Church Culture*

¹ Westminster Confession of Faith, Chapter II, Sections 1-2.

God put this power to work in Christ when he raised him from the dead and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly places, far above all rule and authority and power and dominion, and above every name that is named, not only in this age but also in the age to come. And he has put all things under his feet and has made him the head over all things for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills all in all.

Ephesians 1:20-23

✓ **A Church with a Christ Centered Message in all of it's teachings**

Luke 24: 27 Then beginning with Moses and all the prophets, he interpreted to them the things about himself in all the scriptures... 44 Then he said to them, "These are my words that I spoke to you while I was still with you—that everything written about me in the law of Moses, the prophets, and the psalms must be fulfilled." 45 Then he opened their minds to understand the scriptures, 46 and he said to them, "Thus it is written, that the Messiah is to suffer and to rise from the dead on the third day, 47 and that repentance and forgiveness of sins is to be proclaimed in his name to all nations, beginning from Jerusalem.

1Cor. 2:1

When I came to you, brothers and sisters, I did not come proclaiming the mystery of God to you in lofty words or wisdom. 2 For I decided to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ, and him crucified.

✓ **A Church that shuns a "worship for" vs. a "for worship" orientation:**

Evangelicalism believed it, too, had to justify itself by pointing to what it produced. The practical outcomes pointed to by evangelicalism to show its utility and relevance originally were not so different from those of liberalism. ... both evangelicalism and liberalism share the same "practical" and "this-worldly" orientation.

William H. Smith

What is the "end game" at CPC? Is it to "worship" God for his glory or is it something else?

For my name's sake, I defer my anger, for the sake of my praise I restrain it for you, so that I may not cut you off.

Isaiah 48:9

Thus says the Lord GOD: It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act, but for the sake of my holy name... I will save you... It is not for your sake that I will act, says the Lord GOD; let that be known to you... Then the nations that are left all around you shall know that I, the LORD, have rebuilt the ruined places, and replanted that which was desolate; I, the LORD, have spoken, and I will do it.

Ezekiel 36: 22-29, 32, 36

Our Worship itself--

"God's worthiness ensures that God-centered worship could never be in vain."

J.R. Neuhaus

- ✓ A Church wherein doxology IS good evangelism

Paul's observation concerning public worship and witness:

"If therefore the whole church comes together... and if an unbeliever enters... " they are "called to account by all, the secrets of their hearts are disclosed and so, falling on their face, they will worship God and declare that God is really among you..." 1Cor. 14:23ff

An Interesting Testimony:

The world had not satisfied me the way it had promised, the way I had anticipated. The world's message and methods had hung me out to dry. I hungered desperately for something. Someone, "out of this world." (I was) broken and longing for something transcendent... I was very thankful when I walked into a church that was very different: A church where the otherness of God was sensed immediately. In the music, in the message and in the mingling afterward, it was clear that God was the guest of honor there... I had suffered the consequences of the modern world's emphasis on the individual and I was unbelievably refreshed to discover a place that took the focus off of me and put it on him... I was drawn in by the glorious mystery of it all. I was being evangelized, not by a man-centered show, but by a God-centered atmosphere... it was quite literally, "out of this world."

W. Tullian Tchividjian

Our *ambition* in sum: Whatever else should characterize CPC, it should be characterized by doxology leading to reverence! Those who attend our service ought to sense that they are meeting with an "awe-full" being, even GOD HIMSELF!

Our chief end is to glorify God and enjoy Him forever!

Westminster Shorter Catechism # 1

2. Our Ultimate Confidence is in the Power of the Gospel that changes EVERYTHING!

What is the Gospel?

The Gospel IS the power of God unto salvation!

Rom. 1:16

For I am not ashamed of the **gospel**; it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who has faith, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.

The Gospel pertains to all things in life, not just life after death!

Phil. 1:27

Only, live your life in a manner worthy of the **gospel** of Christ, so that, whether I come and see you or am absent and hear about you, I will know that you are standing firm in one spirit, striving side by side with one mind for the faith of the **gospel**

The Gospel is both a message and a transforming power as accomplished by the Holy Spirit

1Th. 1:5

because our message of the **gospel** came to you not in word only, but also in power and in the Holy Spirit and with full conviction; just as you know what kind of persons we proved to be among you for your sake.

What is the gospel?

We believe that the gospel *is* the supernatural *power* of God unto salvation wherein the life of God is given to all who believe in Jesus Christ. It is the free gifts of God's grace and possessed by faith alone. The life of God that is given to us includes both eternal life *after* this life, and also an increasingly transformed life *in the present*. The Gospel is not just "theology", but the way we do theology. The gospel is not just a message to believe, but a transforming power We that changes our approach to relationships, motives for doing what we do, suffering hardship, our approach to the world-- in short, our approach to everything! We desire to be a gospel centered church wherein the gospel exudes through everything we do as a church and individually.

Our Vision:

Driving Question: *What would it look like for CPC to be gospel driven? What does the Gospel Change?*

- ✓ **Changes how we grow in holiness (sanctification)**

The Prevailing Power of Constraining Love Eph. 3:14-21.

Holiness and service is proportionate to our affections such that we must experience the power of God's love in the gospel in order to love God, grow in holiness and avoid burnout. It is perhaps counter intuitive, but to produce greater godliness and holiness, we ought then to promote a greater participation in and appreciation for the love of God as revealed in the gospel... Illus. "The Water Heater" E.g. "Heart occupation is the secret to holiness!

- ✓ **Changes the way we think about suffering and weakness**

We are prone to lose heart in life when we glory in our strengths! Paul's remedy is to embrace our weaknesses and struggles as related to unveiling the power of God, rather than to fight them as if ultimate enemies of the gospel. E..g we are like jars of clay through whom God's power is manifest in our weakness in ministry.. We should therefore foster in ourselves and in our church a greater willingness to confess our sins one to another, to acknowledge our weaknesses, even as this is the context whereby God's power is manifest and we are enabled to not lose heart. Discouragement is ultimately rooted in thinking we need something more than we really need it! e.g. the gospel leads us to repent of anything that has become more important in our lives than God and his power working in us—for instance, what makes us discouraged--- is it not something that has become more important to us than the glory of God!

- ✓ **Changes how we relate to one another in the church**

Rather than being defensive, we are able to confess. Rather than boasting of our morals and righteousness, we boast in our weakness such as to bring us back to the cross of Christ with nothing to prove. Rather

than being judgmental in order to hide our own guilt, we forgive as we have been forgiven. In other words, at the root of all bad relationships is self love—albeit either through self-salvation where we need to save others in order to save ourselves (co-dependency) or self-serving—where we need others to save us ... the gospel alone tells us to that we cannot save ourselves nor can anyone save except Christ... we therefore repent of the idols of relationship, however they are manifest, and by receiving Christ's love, are enabled to freely, unconditionally love others... In the example of marriages, we repent of making an idol of our marriage, knowing that we are made complete only in Christ, so that we are free now to minister in love rather than to manipulate in self-love.

✓ **Changes the way we relate to people in the world and witness**

We are *in and for the world while being other worldly*, but surely not *against* the world. The gospel oriented church then is in the world, for the world, if not "of the world." We are therefore and first, compelled to share the gospel out of generosity and love, not guilt. Second, we are freed from the fear of being ridiculed or hurt by others since we already have the favor of God by grace, Third... we can be humble in our dealings with others, rather than arrogant and judgmental, because the grace of the gospel makes us more willing to be aware of the sin in our own lives, and less threatened by the common goodness/gifts that are in non-Christians lives! Fourth, because we are aware that saving faith is only something God can give, we are no longer dependent upon our ability to coerce, convince or influence, again, we share the gospel because it is part of us and we are genuinely excited about it.

Our confidence in summary:

The gospel is not just the "A-B-C" but the "A-to-Z" of the Christian life. The gospel is not just the way to enter the kingdom, but is the way to address every problem and is the way to grow at every step. If we believe we can find our own worth and meaning through performance, then we will become either proud and disdainful of others (if we reach our goals), or else discouraged and self-loathing (if we fail our goals). But the gospel creates an entirely new self-image.

First, it tells us that we are more wicked than we ever dared believe, but more loved and accepted in Christ than you ever dared to hope—at the same time. In fact, if the gospel is true, the more you see your sin, the more certain you are that you were saved by sheer grace and the more precious and electrifying that grace is to you. So the gospel gives us enormous power to admit our flaws.

Then secondly, the knowledge of our acceptance in Christ makes (for the first time) the law of God a beauty instead of a burden. We come to use it to delight the One who has enriched us so mightily—instead of using it to get his attention or win his favor. The first way makes the moral and sacrificial life a joy; the second way makes it a burden.

Therefore the gospel changes everything. It brings down racial barriers by melting away racial pride OR inferiority. It brings down psychological problems by melting away self inflation OR self-hatred. It brings down personal facades, for we are free to admit who we are.

Tim Keller

3. Our Ultimate Strategy is *Churchly*

a. The Church is Essential To The Gospel

Eph.2: 1-10—the two fold “once...now” framework as applied to both individual and corporate salvation in order to partake of the “full” gospel.

Eph. 2:19 So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are citizens with the saints and also members of the **household of God**, 20 built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, with Christ Jesus himself as the cornerstone. 21 In him the whole structure is joined together and grows into a **holy temple** in the Lord; 22 in whom you also are built together the Spirit into a **dwelling place for God**.

A Biblical Observation:

Throughout the Old and New Covenant history, Salvation and Divine Presence go hand in hand—there is no salvation apart from Divine presence— and there is no presence apart from mediating institutions divinely regulated! This is woven into the very fabric of Biblical history from the very beginning—starting with even the creation event itself as a saving event as accomplished by divine presence in Genesis, to the consummation of the New Creation even by divine presence in Revelation! Therefore, Paul's teaching for us under the New Covenant was no different than the prophetic teaching under the Old Covenant, that salvation is described with the promise "I will dwell with them" (2 Cor. 6:16), even as salvation is defined as ultimately accomplished by the complete restoration of divine presence in our midst.

Rev. 21:3 And I heard a loud voice from heaven saying, "Behold, the **tabernacle** of God is with men, and He will dwell with them, and they shall be His people. God Himself will be with them and be their God.

The whole of the Bible—as the book of redemption, is “not (merely) the story of ideas about God, but the story of the people of God...the gospel does not come to each of us in isolation. It comes to us through a particular book and through a particular fellowship... it is a false spirituality, divorced from the whole teaching of the Bible which regards this visible and continuing church as of subordinate importance for the life of Christ... God meets us through his people here and now in the form of an actual invitation into the fellowship of a body of people calling themselves one Church.”

Lesslie Newbigin, *The Reunion of the Church*, pp.27,29

Vision:

What changes about ministry if the church is an essential element of the gospel?

1. The Priority of “koinonia” as by means of the mediated presence of God acting through the church

✓ The Priority of Word

The Prophetic Role of the Church — *Apostolic Confession/Preaching:*

Romans 10:14ff

“But how are they to call on one in whom they have not believed? And how are they to believe in one whom they have never heard? And how are they to hear without a preacher? And how are they to preach unless they are sent?”.

Titus 1:5, 9

"I left you behind in Crete for this reason so that you should put in order what remained to be done by appointing elders in every town....He must have a firm grasp of the word that is trustworthy in accordance with the teaching so that he may be able both to preach with sound doctrine and to refute those who contradict it".

✓ **The Priority of Sacraments**

The Priestly Role of the Church – Covenant initiation and renewal rites,

1 Cor. 10:16ff

"The cup of blessing that we bless, is it not a *sharing* in the blood of Christ? The bread that we break, is it not a *sharing* in the body of Christ....You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons. You cannot partake of the table of the Lord and the table of demons....For to begin with when you come together as a church..., For as often as you eat this bread and drink the cup, you preach the Lord's death until he comes".

Acts 2:38

Peter said to them, "Repent, and be *baptized* every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ so that your sins may be forgiven; and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.

1Pet. 3:21

And *baptism*, which this prefigured, now saves you—not as a removal of dirt from the body, but as an appeal to God for a good conscience, through the resurrection of Jesus Christ,

✓ **The Priority of Pastoral Care through discipline and mercy**

The Kingly Role

1 Peter 5:2ff

"Shepherd the flock of God that is in your charge, exercising oversight...and when the chief shepherd appears".

Acts 20:28-31

"Keep watch over yourselves and over all the flock, of which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to shepherd the church of God that he obtained with the blood of his own Son. I know that after I have gone, savage wolves will come in among you, not sparing the flock. Some even from your own group will come distorting the truth in order to entice the disciples to follow them. Therefore be alert, remembering that for three years I did not cease night or day to warn everyone with tears"

1Pet. 4:8

Above all, maintain constant love for *one another*, for love covers a multitude of sins. **9** Be hospitable to *one another* without complaining. **10** Like good stewards of the manifold grace of God, serve *one another* with whatever gift each of you has received.

2. An Corporate and Organic Model For Ministry and Spirituality (New Israel)

The gospel is accomplished NOT primarily by individuals, but individuals organically united to others..

After 11 chapters of doctrinal instruction, the first issue Paul addresses is the lifestyle and the conduct of the community. Romans 12: 1 reads, "Therefore, I urge you, brothers, in view of God's mercy to offer you bodies (plural) as a living sacrifice (singular), holy and acceptable to God which is your spiritual worship" It is the church as a corporate body that is in view here as the living sacrifice, not the lives of individual Christians.

In 1 Corinthians 12, Paul uses the metaphor of a body to emphasize the fact that we belong to one another and need each other. We are all baptized in the one Spirit and as partakers of that one Spirit are to be seen as intimately related and connected to one another. We are not to say "I don't need you" to anyone within the community. We are affected by what is going on in one another's lives whether we know it or not: "If one part suffers, every part suffers with it; if one part is honored every part rejoices with it."

Church Related work IS a Calling, no less so than our other two callings of public service and family!

As per Augustine: "There is no salvation outside of the church."

As per Luther: Outside this Christian church, there is no salvation or forgiveness of sins, but everlasting death and damnation."

✓ **Organic Model of doing pastoral care**

A Collaborating One Anothering

Rom. 12:10

love one another with mutual affection; outdo one another in showing honor.

Rom. 15:14

¶ I myself feel confident about you, my brothers and sisters, that you yourselves are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge, and able to instruct one another.

1Cor. 12:25

that there may be no dissension within the body, but the members may have the same care for one another.

Gal. 6:2

Bear one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ.

Eph. 4:25

¶ So then, putting away falsehood, let all of us speak the truth to our neighbors, for we are members of one another.

Eph. 4:32

and be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God in Christ has forgiven you.

1Th. 4:18

Therefore encourage one another with these words.

Heb. 10:24

And let us consider how to provoke one another to love and good deeds,

James 5:16

Therefore confess your sins to one another, and pray for one another, so that you may be healed. The prayer of the righteous is powerful and effective.

1Pet. 4:9

Be hospitable to one another without complaining.

1John 1:7

but if we walk in the light as he himself is in the light, we have fellowship with one another, and the blood of Jesus his Son cleanses us from all sin.

Individual to Individual

Small Group

Elders and Pastors

✓ **Organic Model for Evangelism:**

In the Old Covenant, we see clearly that the Great Commission was directed to the people of Israel as a corporate body-- Israel, as a nation, was called a "priestly kingdom and a holy nation" whereby God's law and grace was revealed to the nations...(Ex.19:3-6) Likewise, in the NC, the "church" is the "Israel of God" (Gal.6:16, Rom.9:5-6). Peter then applied the great commission to the corporate church when he states in 1 Peter 2:9, "But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's own people, in order that you may proclaim the mighty acts of him who called you out of darkness into his marvelous light. 10 Once you were not a people, but now you are God's people; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy."

Thus,

1. Collaborating Approach to Evangelism:

Authorized Preaching coupled with lay witness, invitation and sharing...

2. "Household Evangelism"

Jonathan Edwards:

In the fall of the year 1734 I proposed it to the young people that they should agree among themselves to spend the evenings after lectures in social religion, and to that end divide themselves into several companies to meet in various parts of the town; which was accordingly done, and those meetings have been since continued and the example imitated by elder people.

Related Goals:

- ✓ Not a church "with Small groups" but a church "of" Small Groups" wherein the organic nature of the church can be more effectively and authentically expressed in proximity to where people are and live.

Our Strategy in sum:

Fellowship is vital for our spiritual health and central to the church's true life. It is two dimensional, and it is vertical before it can be horizontal. That is we must know the reality of fellowship with the Father and his Son Jesus Christ before we can know the reality of fellowship with each other in our common relationship to God. Christian fellowship is seeking to share with others what God has made known of him to you, while letting them share with you what they know of him as a means of finding strength, refreshment and instruction for one's own soul. Gratefully one receives what others share. Equally, one labors to give. And in the giving, no less than in the taking, one finds renewal and strength. Fellowship is an expression of both love and humility. It springs from a desire to bring benefit to others coupled with a sense of personal weakness and need. It has a double motive: the wish to help and the wish to be helped, the wish to edify and the wish to be edified. It is thus a corporate seeking by Christian people to know God better through sharing with each other what individually they have learned already.

J. I. Packer